```
\newcommand {\insfig}[4] {
% 4 args: file, scale, caption, label
% scale: 0.1, 0.2, 0.5, etc.
% needs the graphicx package
\begin{figure}[htb]
\includegraphics[scale=#2]{#1}
\caption{#3}
\label{#4}
\end{figure}
}
```

With this definition in place, you can insert captioned figures with just one command, as follows:

```
\insfig{filename}{scale}{caption}{label}
```

Creating presentations

LaTeX presentation packages give you the means to make truly portable presentations. Apart from offering numerous slick looking, colour-coordinated themes, they also give you overlays and progressive disclosure of slide content. All that needs to be done is to carry a PDF version of the presentation generated by LaTeX, without bothering about the version of the presentation software the podium laptop might be running, as long it has a PDF reader available.

The Beamer package

Beamer is a well-documented \ltx\ presentation package. We focus on it because it is intuitive even if it has a long—but not steep—learning curve. Powerdot is another prominent presentation package.

In Beamer, each slide is a frame. You can also use standard \ltx\commands such as \verb+\section+ that you would use with the article document class making it easy to transfer material between articles and slides and \textit{vice-versa}.

The following is a basic Beamer template that you can start playing with and customising:

```
%Sample Beamer Template for LaTeX
\documentclass{beamer}
\title[Short Title]{Long Title}
\author{Author1 and Author2}
\date{\today}
\usetheme{Warsaw}

\begin{document}
\maketitle

\begin{frame}
\frametitle{Slide1: Progressive Disclosure}
\setbeamercovered{dynamic}

Item 1 \\ \pause
Item 2 \\ \pause
Item 3 \\
\end{frame}
\begin{frame}
\frametitle{Slide2: Another Progressive
Disclosure Style}
\begin{itemize}[<+->]
\item Item 1
\item Item 2
\item Item 3
\end{itemize}
\end{frame}
\begin{frame}{Slide 3: Multi-Column}
\begin{columns}[c]
\column{0.4\textwidth}
\centering
Item 1\\
Item 2\\
Item 3
\column{0.4\textwidth}
\centering
You can include a graphic here.
\end{columns}
\vfill
\begin{center}
Lots more information at \\
\scriptsize www.ctan.org/\\
tex-archive/macros/LaTeX/contrib/\\
beamer/doc/beameruserguide.pdf
\end{center}
\end{frame}

\end{document}
```

Transitioning to typesetting

LaTeX is a vast subject that has been extensively discussed and written about. With this and the previous article, we have just skimmed its surface. If great content takes pride of place in our minds, then precise typesetting must stand right next to it to create that good impression. LaTeX, because of its batch-mode operation, brings portable, precision typesetting even to relatively lower-end machines. So will you let LaTeX typeset your next magnum opus? END

References

[1] *http://www.LaTeXtemplates.com/* is a good place for LaTeX templates.
[2] *http://www.ctan.org/tex-archive/macros/LaTeX/contrib/beamer/doc/beameruserguide.pdf* for Beamer documentation.
[3] Wikibooks has a comprehensive guide on LaTeX.

By: Gurudutt Talgery

The author likes exploring the contribution of FOSS to improving the productivity of knowledge workers and writing about it.